BATTERY (Continued)

OPERATION

The battery is designed to store electrical energy in a chemical form. When an electrical load is applied to the terminals of the battery, an electrochemical reaction occurs. This reaction causes the battery to discharge electrical current from its terminals. As the battery discharges, a gradual chemical change takes place within each cell. The sulfuric acid in the electrolyte combines with the plate materials, causing both plates to slowly change to lead sulfate. At the same time, oxygen from the positive plate material combines with hydrogen from the sulfuric acid, causing the electrolyte to become mainly water. The chemical changes within the battery are caused by the movement of excess or free electrons between the positive and negative plate groups. This movement of electrons produces a flow of electrical current through the load device attached to the battery terminals.

As the plate materials become more similar chemically, and the electrolyte becomes less acid, the voltage potential of each cell is reduced. However, by charging the battery with a voltage higher than that of the battery itself, the battery discharging process is reversed. Charging the battery gradually changes the sulfated lead plates back into sponge lead and lead dioxide, and the water back into sulfuric acid. This action restores the difference in the electron charges deposited on the plates, and the voltage potential of the battery cells. For a battery to remain useful, it must be able to produce high-amperage current over an extended period. A battery must also be able to accept a charge, so that its voltage potential may be restored.

The battery is vented to release excess hydrogen gas that is created when the battery is being charged or discharged. However, even with these vents, hydrogen gas can collect in or around the battery. If hydrogen gas is exposed to flame or sparks, it may ignite. If the electrolyte level is low, the battery may arc internally and explode. If the battery is equipped with removable cell caps, add distilled water whenever the electrolyte level is below the top of the plates. If the battery cell caps cannot be removed, the battery must be replaced if the electrolyte level becomes low.

DIAGNOSIS AND TESTING - BATTERY

The battery must be completely charged and the terminals should be properly cleaned and inspected before diagnostic procedures are performed. Refer to Battery System Cleaning for the proper cleaning procedures, and Battery System Inspection for the proper battery inspection procedures. Refer to Standard Procedures for the proper battery charging procedures.

MICRO 420 BATTERY TESTER

The Micro 420 automotive battery tester is designed to help the dealership technicians diagnose the cause of a defective battery. Follow the instruction manual supplied with the tester to properly diagnose a vehicle. If the instruction manual is not available refer to the standard procedure in this section, which includes the directions for using the Micro 420 battery tester.

WARNING: IF THE BATTERY SHOWS SIGNS OF FREEZING, LEAKING OR LOOSE POSTS, DO NOT TEST, ASSIST-BOOST, OR CHARGE. THE BATTERY MAY ARC INTERNALLY AND EXPLODE. PERSONAL INJURY AND/OR VEHICLE DAMAGE MAY RESULT.

WARNING: EXPLOSIVE HYDROGEN GAS FORMS IN AND AROUND THE BATTERY. DO NOT SMOKE, USE FLAME, OR CREATE SPARKS NEAR THE BATTERY. PERSONAL INJURY AND/OR VEHICLE DAMAGE MAY RESULT.

WARNING: THE BATTERY CONTAINS SULFURIC ACID, WHICH IS POISONOUS AND CAUSTIC. AVOID CONTACT WITH THE SKIN, EYES, OR CLOTHING. IN THE EVENT OF CONTACT, FLUSH WITH WATER AND CALL A PHYSICIAN IMMEDIATELY. KEEP OUT OF THE REACH OF CHILDREN.

A battery that will not accept a charge is faulty, and must be replaced. Further testing is not required. A fully-charged battery must be load tested to determine its cranking capacity. A battery that is fully-charged, but does not pass the load test, is faulty and must be replaced.

NOTE: Completely discharged batteries may take several hours to accept a charge. Refer to Standard Procedures for the proper battery charging procedures.

STANDARD PROCEDURE

STANDARD PROCEDURE - BATTERY CHARGING

Battery charging is the means by which the battery can be restored to its full voltage potential. A battery is fully-charged when:

- All of the battery cells are gassing freely during battery charging.
- A green color is visible in the sight glass of the battery built-in test indicator.